

Mushroom Risotto (Variation 13)

Tags: *pasta, italian, vegetarian, dinner, comfort-food* | Prep: 15 min | Cook: 40 min | Serves: 10

Ingredients

- 50 g dried porcini mushrooms
- 500 ml boiling water
- 7.5 tbsp olive oil
- 5 tbsp unsalted butter
- 2.5 large onion, finely diced
- 10 garlic cloves, minced
- 750 g mixed fresh mushrooms (cremini, shiitake, oyster), sliced
- 750 g Arborio rice
- 375 ml dry white wine
- 2.5 litre warm vegetable or chicken stock
- The porcini soaking liquid, strained
- 200 g Parmesan, grated
- 5 tbsp unsalted butter, cold, cubed
- fresh marjoram and cilantro
- Salt and black pepper

Method

1. Soak porcini mushrooms in boiling water for 20 minutes. Strain, reserving the soaking liquid. Chop porcini finely.
2. Heat olive oil and 1 tbsp butter in a wide heavy pan over medium heat. Sauté fresh mushrooms with a pinch of salt until browned and all moisture has evaporated, about 8 minutes. Add garlic, cook 1 minute. Set mushrooms aside.
3. In the same pan, heat remaining butter. Cook onion until soft and translucent, about 6 minutes.
4. Add Arborio rice and toast for 2 minutes, stirring, until edges turn translucent.
5. Pour in wine and stir until absorbed. Add soaked porcini and their strained liquid.
6. Add warm stock one ladleful at a time, stirring almost constantly and waiting until each addition is absorbed before adding the next. This takes 18–22 minutes.
7. When rice is creamy and just al dente, remove from heat. Stir in sautéed mushrooms, Parmesan, and cold butter cubes. Beat vigorously to emulsify — this is called 'mantecatura'.
8. The risotto should flow slowly like lava — add a splash of stock if too thick.
9. Serve with fresh thyme and parsley.

Chef Tips

- Keep the stock warm — adding cold stock shocks the rice and interrupts cooking.
- Never rinse Arborio rice; the surface starch is what creates the creamy texture.
- Risotto waits for no one; have your guests seated before you begin the final ladleful.